

KF21 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we are learning about the self-hate experience. Self-hate is the product of the condemning judgments that we make when we fail to achieve our idealized standards. It brings to consciousness the deep judgments that we carry with us all the time. However, regardless of the pain that self-hate causes, self-hate is not our enemy. The real enemy is the Idol Self. This Idol depends on the fear of scathing judgment to lash us into submission and to maintain its pride system. But if you walk courageously through the valley of the shadow of death, working with your tools, you will drain the stagnant storage tank of self-condemnation and judgment that fuels your self-hate. The awareness of self-hate will become an invitation for exploration rather than the paralyzing, excruciating torment that you have experienced in the past.

For the last few months, we have been training our minds to observe what is within us, bubbling up from the depths of our souls. This month we will practice observing those bubbles, the evidence of our weaknesses and strengths, without getting caught up in the feelings, motivations, and behaviors of self-hate. With training, we learn to step back from self-hate, choose life, give a blessing, fortify our True Self, and strengthen our connection with God.

The Self-Hate Massage

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Bring to mind an area of your life that chronically stirs up self-hate for you. Perhaps you have made a mistake, or perhaps your limitations are preventing you from achieving your dreams and goals. Something in your life may be imperfect, or you might fear that you are not good enough. Perhaps you have challenged your Idol Self in some way. We will connect that hurt to our breathing and get acquainted with it using our KF tools.

CONSIDER

Take a moment to collect yourself within your present space. Feel the air or the clothing on your skin. Notice any noises. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now consider this area of self-hate. Notice the discomfort you feel when you think of it. Even though you hate this thing, allow it to rest inside your skin for one minute, without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

COMPASSION

As you breathe, experience yourself as a creature with limitations breathing in a material world. *(Pause)* You are not a god. *(Pause)* As you breathe in and out, imagine your area of self-hate moving in and out with the breath, massaging the place in your soul that is stuck or cramped. For one minute, give it and receive it with compassion. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

CLEANSE

Notice your entire body as it breathes. *(Pause)* Breathe with your mind, body, and soul as you open the doors of the prison cells of your shame, rage, disappointments, and guilt. *(Pause)* Allow the clean air to sweep through those dark, stagnant places for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our hymn for this confession is *My Faith Looks Up to Thee*.

While life's dark maze I tread,
And griefs around me spread,
Be Thou my guide;
Bid darkness turn to day,
Wipe sorrow's tears away,
Nor let me ever stray
From Thee aside.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 5 reminds us that our self-hate is a tragic and colossal waste of glory and potential:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

The Idol's system is like a fascist regime that suppresses the real power of the people. The word *suppressed* reminds us that beneath the Idol's system there is another power at work—a power that we can access to free ourselves from the Idol and actualize our potential.

All tyrants use fear to control others and our inner tyrant, the Idol, is no different. It uses the fear of hurt pride and self-condemnation to control us. Fear is the strongest motivator that most of us know, and we have learned to turn it to a dubious advantage. Fear keeps us moving. It forces us to take action, and depending on our neurotic development, we habitually fight or flee when events trigger our fear. Through fight or flight, we create the illusion that we are doing something about our fear.

A mastery person was proud of his imagined sense of justice. He hated himself whenever he showed mercy to someone, so he would regularly flee from opportunities to be merciful and retreat into his habitual patterns of aggression. He was more terrified of his self-hate than he was of the damage that he caused by attacking.

A resigned person felt the terror of self-hate whenever an event revealed her inner conflicts and her need for self-development. She had a taboo against making changes in her life and was proud of her imagined ability to detach from her feelings. Whenever she was presented with an invitation to grow, she would flee by shutting down.

The strange thing about our relationship with self-hate is that we fear it and need it at the same time. So, although we fear the damaging effects of self-hate, we often actively do things to keep our self-hate alive. We need self-hate to keep us moving toward our imagined glory; we cannot afford to let something die that spurs us on. To keep our self-hate alive, we hurt others and ourselves, neglect our training and our rest, fumble our jobs and our relationships, and revert to addictive, compulsive behaviors. We then concoct a story that focuses on our misoriented choices, but this story is actually a smokescreen that obscures our understanding of the real problem, which is our Idol's hurt pride.

When we make the judgment that our choices and "mistakes" fall short of our imagined standards of perfection, our pride is wounded, and we then hate ourselves and often despise anything or anyone connected to us. Our self-hate invites self-torment and we punish ourselves with degrading and destructive thoughts, feelings, and actions. The fear of self-torment becomes a powerful motivator that relentlessly drives us to work harder to achieve our Idol's impossible and ever-shifting standards. Unfortunately, and inevitably, we meet with more "failure" and end up crippled with more self-hate as we try to force ourselves beyond our limitations and created design.

Here are some suggestions that might help you compassionately manage your self-hate:

1. Review Dr. Horney's book

Continue to explore *Neurosis and Human Growth* looking for insights into self-hate.² Make a list of areas that could be self-hate hotspots for you.

2. Write a letter of compassion to yourself

What would you say to encourage a friend who is in self-hate? What would encourage you? Write down your thoughts in a letter of encouragement to yourself and keep this letter in your KF notebook. When you begin to break free, your Idol will invariably use self-hate as a whip to force you back into line and suppress any efforts you might make toward your healing. So, in this letter, remind yourself that we often experience self-hate when we refuse to comply with our Idol.

3. Talk to your Karis Link

Hopefully, your Karis Link has learned some tips for managing self-hate. You might ask them to do a KF worksheet with you. Together, consider and appreciate the progress you have made since joining Karis Fellowships.

4. Talk to someone who can help you reconnect to reality

This person can be anyone, a professional or just someone wise, who can give you a "reality check" and point you back to the Believe It Path. Self-hate is largely the product of illusions. A reality check reminds you of what is true, what is real, and what is your business.

5. In the midst of your misery, remember to pray

If you are training hard, ask God to give you an encouraging present or gift. Watch for His care and then return to Him a gift of gratitude. God's mercy is greater than your self-hate.

6. **Make a gratitude list**

Write down the things for which you are thankful. Gratitude creates soothing endorphin chemistry that helps your mind and body return to the Christian reality of positive hope.³

7. **Mindfully breathe**

Learn to respond to self-hate with mindful breathing, connecting to your body and to God.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Shepherd, what does my self-hate reveal to You about me? What can it reveal to me about You?
(Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 **SHARING**

1:00 **BIBLE TEACHING**

We are our own worst enemy. Let's stop blaming others or our circumstances and acknowledge that our real enemy is ourselves.

Last week we began looking at Psalm 23 from a KF perspective. Here is a summary of what we learned:

1. **The Lord our Shepherd meets our real needs**

Jesus said, "I am the good Shepherd."⁴ He provides the security and support that we need as we give up our Idol's law and pride system.

2. **It is Jesus who restores, or repairs, our soul**

Our redeemed and alive soul is our True Self. Jesus created our soul and He knows how to repair it. He wants to help us become the people He created us to be.

3. **The Idol Self will not support the restoration of our soul**

In order to survive and maintain its power, the Idol Self will resist any effort you make to restore your True Self. If you choose humility and freedom, the Idol will fiercely oppose your efforts using fear and self-hate as its weapons. You will enter the valley of the shadow of death.

4. **The Shepherd's rod and staff guide and help us**

Secure in the Shepherd's care, we can refuse to be guided by our shoulds, taboos, and claims and, instead, learn to respond to His guidance. With skillful hands, the Shepherd uses His rod and staff to train, direct, and protect us, meeting our needs and responding to our choices. The Shepherd knows what particular training and provision each person requires to help them maintain an oriented path.

Now let's look at the last two verses of **Psalm 23**, which Nancy has translated using some alternative vocabulary to help expand our understanding.

⁵You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations.
You have enriched my head with oil;

My cup overflows with abundance.

⁶Good things and kindnesses will follow after me all the days of my life,
And throughout my life I will return to the house of the Lord.

Take a deep breath.

Most of us have heard that the Lord prepares a table before us *in the presence of enemies*. According to Strong's Concordance, the Hebrew word for enemies also means a narrow place, or a binding, as in being tied up. There is a sense of distress and limitation as in a besieged city. To give us a more thorough understanding of this psalm, Nancy has conveyed this idea of restriction by using the word *limitations*. When we meet with limitations, we often feel distressed, or under siege, because we perceive these limitations as obstacles to our happiness and satisfaction. Let's listen again to verse 5 in Nancy's translation: *You set in order before me a table with my particular limitations. (Repeat)* Your table is set with limitations that are uniquely yours. They are part of the abundance that is promised to you through the picture of anointing oil and a cup that overflows. How can that be?

Real limitations protect us. The Shepherd knows what we can handle at our present stage of development, and He uses real limitations to help protect us from what we cannot handle. When we mindfully accept what *is*, and courageously sit at the table ordered for *us*, our limitations become part of our strategy rather than the focus of our judgments. This oriented submission to reality invites us to work creatively within our limitations and discover our great potential.⁵

In misorientation, however, we can rarely imagine this potential. We are fixated on what *should* be, so rather than exploring our real potential in a particular situation, we feel discontented and resentful. We look around at other people's tables and feel the unfairness of not having what others have. This is neurotic envy.

The promise that goodness and kindnesses will follow us and that our home is with the Lord our Shepherd inspires us to courageously sit at our own table and stop looking around at other tables.

At this point, we might ask ourselves: *Do I want to leave a trail of goodness, health, and compassionate mercy behind me, or would I rather continue to work hard at actualizing my Idol Self? Do I want to face the realities of my present situation and discover the potential of my particular challenges and strengths, or am I only interested in my judgment of how things should be? What do I want?*

What do you want?

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Shepherd, I want to leave behind me a trail of goodness and kindnesses. Help me make that happen.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and prepare to take a few notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe.

(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider one of your present limitations. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

How does it feel when you *consider one of your present limitations?* *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold in awareness your experience with this limitation. Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this limitation*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* For example, you might recognize what frustration, unfairness, or self-condemnation feels like in your body. You might feel relief. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider one of your present limitations*. Do you feel compelled to judge this limitation as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you make this judgment? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* How might your Idol's pride be hurt if you were to submit to this limitation? How might your True Self be liberated? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*.

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your limitations.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit, who wants to lead you to abundance.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for self-esteem and affection.
- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving for security and comfort.
- As I observe this limitation, I let go of the craving to escape my situation. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to our real glory and to the truth of who you created us to be. With Your rod and staff, train us for the next step as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with the Creation and the community, and with You, for the honor and glory of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *My Faith Looks Up to Thee* by Ray Palmer (1808–1887).

² Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

³ simplyfit4life.com/releasing-endorphins-no-its-not-a-disease.

⁴ John 10:11–16.

⁵ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Obstacle_Is_the_Way.

⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.